

film review Diasporic Drama

HOPE AND A LITTLE SUGAR

Director: Tanuja Chandra

Starring: Anupam Kher,

Mahima Chaudhury

Any film that has sugar in its title and a sweetshop owner selling charmingly wrapped bon-bons as its protagonist looks doomed to drown in a sea of saccharine. Especially if it's directed by Tanuja Chandra, whose last film, *Zindaggi Rocks*, gave viewers terminal diabetes. But *Hope and a Little Sugar* is one of those little films that uses world-changing events as wallpaper without bringing the house down. A young Muslim boy (played with remarkable confidence by newcomer Amit Sial) flees Mumbai after the 1992 riots, landing up as a



A WHOLE NEW WORLD: (From left) Sial, Chaudhury, Kher struggling photographer in New York, only to get caught in the backlash after 9/11. Mahima Chaudhury plays a somewhat merry widow with whom he falls in love, much to her Sikh father-in-law's discomfort.

The movie captures the diaspora's desire to cling to old-fashioned conventions in a New York that looks suspiciously calm. But amidst all the artfully shot

photographs of Chaudhury and the inevitable news footage of the twin towers, there is some fine acting here. The English-Punjabi dialogue sounds quite real in what was a collaboration between Chandra and her American partners, mostly over email. It's the way filmmakers will work in the future, sharing skills at a fraction of global studio budgets. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

recommendation A Taste for Waste

MUMBAI It's a theme that has engaged him for over a decade now, and it's an exhibition that is as appealing to the audience's eye as any—except that it is 'Trash'. Vivan Sundaram's exhibition of installation, photographs and videos is based on the economy and aesthetics of second-hand goods and urban waste. The colour and texture of industrial waste, dirty toothbrushes, plastic toys, tin cans and soiled milk bags add to the visual flavour of Sundaram's art. Constructing a large cityscape with garbage from his own studio, Sundaram has meditated

upon the visual outcome, through the camera, from several vantage points.

As a theme, Sundaram continues to explore 'trash' in his current works of art—the social implications of waste, the modern fascination with recycled objects, and the modernist procedure of bricolage. His photograph 'Master Plan' is a surveillance view of a garbage-city. 'Barricade', a collection of images, disorients the viewer with its scale, while the soles of old shoes and their shadows make up '12 Bed Ward', a dark, dormitory-sized installation about life lived below ground zero. In the two-channel video installation, 'Tracking (2004-04)', a camera focuses on a studio-set of an elaborately fabricated city, and viewers glimpse a man and a woman—predators, or lovers—traversing the city by night. Sundaram's artwork is on display at Chemould Prescott Road till May 17.



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by Swati Mathur

audiobook Magical Retelling



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Rs 295 per CD

Charkha Audio-books, an imprint of Karadi Tales Company, has



Shobhana

released *Abhijnanashakuntalam*, one of Kalidasa's greatest plays. The story from the Mahabharata speaks of king Dushayanta's love for Shankuntala, daughter of the sage Vishwamitra and the apsara Menaka. The audiobook attempts to recreate this magic for contemporary audiences through an English retelling, mixed with select Sanskrit verses told in a dramatic narrative of Kalidasa's poetry by actor and dancer Shobhana. The audio CD is attractively embedded in a book where illustrations in miniature style depict scenes from the epic drama. The script by Lakshmi Lal, written in a communicative style, manages to recreate Kalidasa's magic for those not lettered in the language of the gods. The music is stark and minimal. Composer Sriram Parasuram has used little orchestration and his voice evokes grandeur befitting Kalidasa's work.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit